THE LIBERAL APPROACH

The tradition of liberal political thought as propounded by liberal thinkers like Immanuel Kant, Thomas Jefferson, James Madison, John Stuart Mill, John Locke, David Hume, Jean–Jacques Rousseau and Adam Smith was revived, adopted and transformed to give birth to the liberal approach to IR. The chief proponents of post-World War I liberalism were Alfred Zimmern, Norman Angell, James T. Shotwell and Woodrow Wilson. They are sometimes referred to as *liberal idealists* or simply *idealists*. E.H. Carr (1939), however, ascribed them as *utopians*.

At the heart of the liberal worldview lie certain basic assumptions about the human rationality and morality, belief in reforming institutions as solutions to problems and most importantly idea about human progress. In the words of David Sidorsky[2] liberalism consists of "In simplest terms, first a conception of man as desiring freedom and capable of exercising rational free choice. Second, it is a perspective on social institutions as open to rational reconstruction in the light of individual needs. It is third, a view of history as progressively perfectible through the continuous application of human reason to social institutions".

Based on their optimism, the liberalists conceptualize the individual as the possessor of rationality and a seat of moral values and virtues and also capable of controlling their basic impulses. They try to justify the irrational and immoral behaviour of the individuals as not the manifestations of flawed human nature but the result of ignorance and misunderstanding, which is possible to overcome through education and reforming of social and political institutions.

Alongside such positive picturization of human beings, the liberals tend to be less emphatic about social and individual conflicts as inevitable. They believe that it is possible to bring about the greatest good for the greatest number that would reap benefits for all and create an order that would maximize individual freedom and material and economic prosperity. The logical corollary of this is the concept of "**harmony of interests**".

Contrary to the realist position that focuses on the possibility of